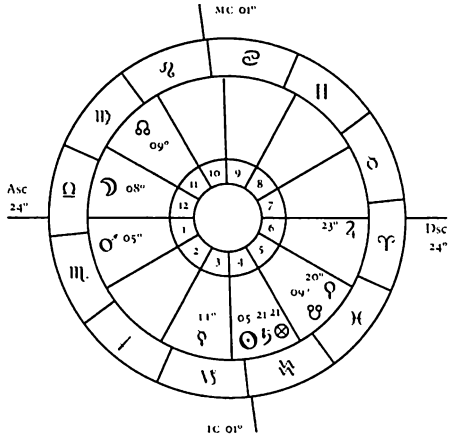



FIGURE 96. CHART OF MARIA VON TRAPP: EQUAL HOUSES

*In the equal house system of house division, the first house begins at the degree of the Ascendant, and each house has exactly 30°. Only when the Ascendant degree falls at 0° will the houses and signs coincide exactly. Usually, however, the houses and signs do not coincide. In this example, Mars is in the first house, Mercury is in the third, Saturn and the Sun are in the fourth, Venus is in the fifth, Jupiter is in the sixth, and the Moon is in the twelfth. All house cusps are the same as the Ascendant and Descendant (24°).*

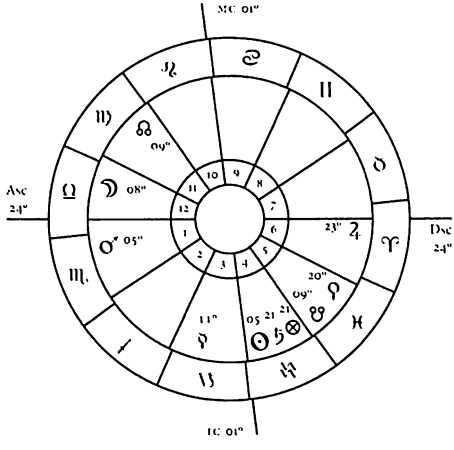



FIGURE 97. CHART OF MARIA VON TRAPP: PORPHYRY HOUSES

*In the Porphyry system of house division, the houses are trisected between the arc of the Ascendant and the Lower Heaven, and between the Ascendant and the Midheaven; these divisions are then projected onto the remaining quadrants of the chart. In this example, Mars is in the first house, Mercury is in the third, Saturn and the Sun are in the fourth, Venus is in the fifth, Jupiter is in the sixth, and the Moon is in the twelfth. The house cusps are: first 24° Libra, second 26° Scorpio, third 28° Sagittarius, fourth 01° Aquarius, fifth 28° Aquarius, sixth 26° Pisces. The degrees of the seventh–twelfth house cusps are the same as their opposite counterparts.*

texts of Vettius Valens and Firmicus Maternus.[5] Here, the degree of the Ascendant marks the *beginning* of the first house, and the interval of the first house extends over the next 30°. Each successive house begins with that same degree as the Ascendant, but in the following zodiacal sign, and each house contains

5 VALENS, *Anthology* 9; FIRMICUS, *Mathesis* 2.21.

another.[4] The Moon's swift motion is thus the basis for the third-house meanings of movement, transition, and change..

While taking short journeys to visit nearby relations, one passes through the villages and communities in the immediate locale, exchanging news and information. Here we see the origins of the third-house significations regarding neighborhood and communications of all kinds. Beginning with news, gossip, rumors, and letters, the third house continues to incorporate all the media innovations by which to share information—scrolls, books, newspapers, magazines, telegrams, telephones, radio, television, computers, the internet, email, websites, blogs, and social media. In the twenty-first century, the third house has grown to symbolize the digital information revolution with sophisticated intelligence and counter-intelligence operations, information technology careers, and data gathering and analysis used in politics and business enterprises.

Peddlers, tradesmen, and merchants also traveled the byways of a local community, selling and trading goods and services, and in the process also transmitting news and information. Thus mercantile activity along with advertising and publicity gradually came to fill the third-house significations. With the advances in mechanics and technology, all means of conveyances via transport—carrying people and goods from one place to another—also became included in this sector.

In 1904, Alan Leo makes a passing reference to Mercury in connection with the third house and associates this sector with the "lower brain mind".[5] His interpretations of signs and planets in the third house include descriptions of various mental tendencies and the ways in which the mind operates. Several decades later, Dane Rudhyar expanded upon this idea with the suggestion that the relationship of a child to their environment was the foundation for the formation of intelligence. In this way, the development of speech, language, motor skills, as well as primary school education, entered the corpus of third-house topics. With these developments, the third house became the repository of the rational-analytical concrete mind, mental abilities, various kinds of intelligence, as well as possible learning and cognitive disabilities. The mercurial function of the rational intellect and the different ways that people think were thus conflated with third-house investigations. Practical knowledge with concrete applications, as contrasted with abstract knowledge (associated with the ninth house), was the mental activity consistent with these new topics. Consciousness studies, research into the brain, the power of positive thinking, and the practices

4 BONATTI, *Book of Astronomy* 2.3.11.

5 Alan LEO, *How to Judge a Nativity* (London: S.N., 1904), chapter 10.

and benefits of meditation, also stood at the cutting edge of the new third-house applications.

The spiritual side of the third house has for the most part been lost in the process of transmission. By reflection, the spiritual and religious topics that are found in the ninth house shine down into the third house, giving the significations of religious observances, sacred rites, and divination.

The cadent houses were all considered unsuitable for conducting profitable dealings. Classified as *metakosmios*—the interspace between worlds—the third house joins the other cadent houses as metaphorically residing in some other space where a person is unworldly or "not of this world". This environment often describes the inner realms of the mind where monastics, mystics, and scholars live. Certainly the religious and scholarly pursuits, alongside travel and pilgrimage, located in the inactive cadent houses do not best facilitate taking care of worldly business. However, these houses can be very potent for the activities of the inner life that was not explicitly conceptualized as such until the establishment of the new discipline of psychology in the nineteenth century.

The ancient thread for our understanding of the third house as inner knowledge and self-arising awareness can be found in a passage by Firmicus Maternus written in the fourth century. He said that Mercury in the third house from the Ascendant indicates priests, mages, chief physicians, mathematicians (astrologers), and those who learn from their own efforts whatever was not handed down by the traditions of others.[6] This view of the third house can be interpreted as an alternate state of consciousness where one can access one's own inner faculty of intuition, which is historically connected to divine inspiration (as opposed to spiritual knowledge gained from an external authority).

At the third-house temple of the Goddess, the Moon draws down the religious and spiritual beliefs from the ninth-house heavens, and brings them closer to home on Earth. Valens tells us that in the third house, some receive revelations from a god, prognosticate the future, prepare sacrifices, or make prayers and votive offerings.[7] The third house thus signifies the rituals, rites, observances, and practices that one performs as a tangible expression of the doctrines and dogmas found in the ninth house of God. In Greece, every *polis* or city-state had its own local divinities, cult sites, rituals, and sacred festival days at the public hearth-altars of the city square. These local practices stood in contrast to those found at the great Panhellenic temples visited as part of long-distance pilgrimages connected to the ninth-house significations.

6 FIRMICUS, *Mathesis* 3.3f.6.
7 VALENS, *Anthology* 4.15.

recent scientific evidence, the Y-chromosome DNA genome identification line which uncovers the ancient group of people from whom one's lineage descends can be traced only through the patrilineal line. By contrast, Jewish religion looks only to the bloodline of the mother to verify Jewishness. The fourth house connects a person not only to their ancestral roots—their DNA and bloodlines—but also to their ethnic, cultural, and ideological heritage. A person comes into this life as the sum total of all their ancestral past, and from that foundation, begins the process of individuation. The importance of ancestor worship, an integral part of many cultural and religious traditions, is part of the familial duties of the fourth house.

The second important topic associated with the fourth house is that of home and hearth—the physical dwelling in which one resides, and the hub of family life. Traditionally, the hearth fire was the focal point of the household where food was cooked—the center of warmth, comfort, and family gathering. In early life, this refers to the environment provided by the parents; in adult life, to the home that each person creates for themselves. Ancient astrologers included household goods and domestic concerns in this sector.

The fourth house also refers to the land on which the house is built and the surrounding property, and by extension all real estate holdings. The personal home and land extend to encompass one's hometown, homeland, and country along with pride and a sense of nationalism. One's place of origin or residence is personified as the Fatherland or Motherland, which inspires people to defend their country and protect their families from attack. Environmental concerns associated with stewardship of the land that provides our foundational support are also relevant. Contemporary movements that advocate recycling, ecology, sustainability, organics, and protection of natural resources have their conceptual basis in the fourth house as the earth itself.

The topics of home, father, and ancestors designated by the fourth house are tied together in the design of the Roman home.[5] The *atrium* was the first room upon entering the house where guests and clients were seated each morning to await an audience with the *pater familias*, the father of the family whose office faced this room. The *atrium* had an open roof that allowed rainwater to be collected in a pool which drained into an underground cistern. The cistern not only insured the water supply, but also provided a direct passageway into the area under the house. The *atrium* was lined with busts of family ancestors made from wax molds of the faces of the deceased created during the burial rites conducted in this room, accompanied by plaques describing their accomplishments.

5 Anna Surjeet, personal conversation.